



The state of the states

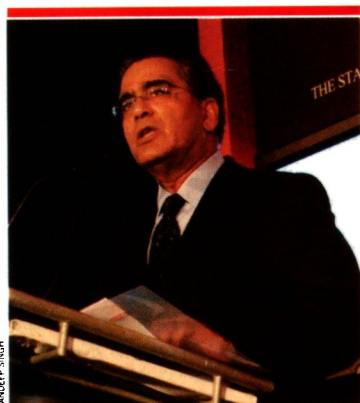
PUNJAB KERALA HIMACHAL PRADESH TAMIL NADU HARYANA UTTARAKHAND MAHARASHTRA GUJARAT

POLITICS OF INCLUS

At the fifth State of the States conclave, there was a broad agreement on the spectre of rising inequality but



FOR A COMMON MINIMUM NATIONAL PROGRAMME: (From left) Lalzama, Thennarasu, Rangasamy, Kamat, Singh Deo, Virbhadr



"We must invest in education, skills and infrastructure to make growth inclusive. Essentially, it all boils down to good governance."

AROON PURIE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF, INDIA TODAY

It was as close as one could get to a National Development Council meeting. Ten chief ministers, one deputy chief minister and ministers from three states debated the causes of rising inequality and the need to push inclusive growth. India Today Editor-in-Chief Aroon Purie set the tone for the debate when he said "the good news is that there is growth but the bad news is that, far from being inclusive, it has increased inequality". Finance Minister P. Chidambaram, in his inaugural address, pointed out that "every square inch of India is ruled by states" and that the laws of economics would work in India, but all stakeholders must work together to find the country its place in the world.

India Today Editor Prabhu Chawla kicked off the debate by asking if there was adequate focus on the basics: agriculture, education and infrastructure. Significantly, there was a broad consensus among the chief ministers that rising inequality was a concern

and the primary focus was the lack of attention to agriculture and education. It may be difficult to discern but there is also an emerging consensus towards a bottom-up approach in development. Indeed Vice-President Mohammad Hamid Ansari delivered the magic mantra in his keynote speech by asking states to make "inclusive growth the sub text of all development." Excerpts from the debate: **Prabhu Chawla, Editor, INDIA TODAY:** Mr Parkash Singh Badal is from a state where agriculture is the primary source of income and for which it has been getting the number one award for the past five years. I will request him to tell us why there is not enough investment in education, in agriculture and in health.

Parkash Singh Badal, chief minister, Punjab: Our finance minister has painted a rosy picture of the country. But in reality, the position is the opposite. We have to plan for the lower, not the upper strata. I would request Mr Purie and Mr Chawla to hold this